

2005, it was absolutely necessary to resist US pressure. Rather than voting for the American move, India should have abstained along with a host of other non-aligned countries and Russia and China. It cannot be argued that Russia is any less opposed to Iran developing a nuclear weapons programme than India is. India's abstention while signalling its opposition to the Iranian ambitions in the nuclear field, would have shown firmness in its dealings with the US.

The second example refers to the quadrilateral meeting involving India, Japan, Australia and the US earlier this year in the Philippines. It was explained away as a conclave of four democracies. In reality, it was a signal that the four countries were coming together to contain China. If there was any ambiguity about the intent, it was cleared away by the quadrilateral naval exercise this month in the Bay of Bengal. The addition of the Singapore navy to those of the four did not detract from the objective.

It is widely held that the quadrilateral initiative is the product of Japanese strategy. But it is a short-sighted move. As the Indo-US nuclear deal has sharply divided Indian opinion about closer relations with the US, the quadrilateral initiative is beginning to divide opinion on relations with Japan. Until now, Indo-Japanese friendship and co-operation *in a bilateral framework* enjoyed wide support in India. Now controversy is inevitable. Growing friendship *in a bilateral mode* between India and Vietnam, India and South Korea, India and Japan and, the lasting Indo-Russian friendship, including strategic dialogues, sends clear signals to China. One presumes that the

Chinese are as good at geography as any other people! They know what they are doing in South Asia.

It was not in India's interest to vote against Iran in 2005 in Vienna. The vote has strained Indo-Iranian relations with a negative impact on petroleum and gas sectors. India acted under US pressure. Notwithstanding the sophisticated language now employed by the US administration, their objective remains the same. Of course, some US Congressmen and senators are as blunt as usual. Similarly, India acted under Japanese pressure on the quadrilateral initiative. Whereas the Chinese could not have reasonably objected to the development of friendship and widening of bilateral cooperation between India and Japan, the quadrilateral move caused them concern and is likely to impede, at least in the short run, the normalisation of India-China relations.

The two issues mentioned above illustrate another phenomenon. As India's relations with various countries become more friendly, there will be much more of give and take. It is to friends that one goes for support.

The government of the day will have to define the national interest with great clarity and stand firm in safeguarding and/or promoting it. It is important to have multiple choices, to be not dependent on one source. Partnership with as many countries as possible must be India's aim. Promiscuity in international relations is not only permissible but is most desirable. To have only one partner shows weakness not loyalty.

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